



The spread of Christianity

From its beginnings in the 1st century CE, Christianity spread from the Middle East to Europe. The mighty Roman Empire made Christianity its official religion in the 4th century, and even after the fall of Rome in the 5th century, the conversion of Germanic kings and their people from paganism to Christianity extended its influence further across Europe. The Church dominated all aspects of everyday life for medieval Christians, from monarchs to peasants. As its influence grew, the Church became wealthy, and a powerful political force in Europe. It owned vast areas of land, had some control over the decisions of Europe's rulers, and could even raise its own armies.

500–1450

◀ SAINT AUGUSTINE

Saint Augustine of Canterbury was sent from Rome to England by Pope Gregory to convert the Anglo-Saxons from paganism to Christianity. He arrived in 597 and successfully converted King Aethelberht I of Kent and many of his subjects. He became the first Archbishop of Canterbury; a position that still exists today.

SAINT BONIFACE ▶

Born in Anglo-Saxon England, Saint Boniface led missions to the Frankish Empire during the 8th century to convert the Germanic peoples there and establish Christian churches. Following his success, he was known as the "Apostle to the Germans." Boniface was killed in 754 and became recognized as a saint soon after.

